

Exemplars

TOWERS OF SAEROTH · PLAYER HANDOUT

Once in a long while a child is born carrying a spark of divine power, and no god will say whose it is.

They are not clerics, not oracles, not chosen and not descended from anybody. No temple ordains them, no revelation precedes them, no lineage predicts them. The spark is simply present, from birth, in a child otherwise indistinguishable from any other, and it belongs to no deity in the pantheon — a fact every faith has confirmed independently and none of them enjoys.

Ten in a generation, across the whole world. That is the number as near as anyone could get it if anyone were in a position to count, and four in five of those never find out. A spark that is never focused does nothing obvious. It makes for a child who is a little too lucky, a little too whole, and who grows old being unremarkable in a way that is very slightly wrong.

What is left after that subtraction is two or three people alive at a time who have actually come into it, and there have been decades with none. **So most of what follows is doctrine about somebody nobody in the room has met.** Every faith and every government in Saeroth has a settled position on exemplars. Between them they are working from perhaps two dozen names in two thousand years, and most of them are working from one.

Ikons

An exemplar's divinity works through **ikons**: objects or features of the body that the spark can live inside. A spear. A crown. A scar. A voice. The item is not enchanted in any conventional sense and no magic can be detected in it until the spark is in it, at which point it is unambiguously, embarrassingly divine.

This is the part that makes exemplars a political problem rather than a curiosity. An ikon is a holy object with no church behind it, and there are half a dozen faiths in Saeroth whose entire authority rests on being the ones who decide what is holy.

Coming into it

A spark that is never focused does nothing and the person carrying it dies ordinary. The few the world hears about are the ones who worked out, young and alone and generally by accident, that the power will go into an object and stay there.

That is also when the dreams start, and there is no record of an exemplar to whom they did not.

Nobody outside can tell you what is in them. Exemplars will not say, and the few who have tried to say could not: they stop mid-sentence, or they write a page and hand you a blank one, and they cannot account for either. Ask one directly and you will usually get a long silence and a change of subject.

Almost nobody has watched one closely enough to say what it is like from the next chair. The best account anywhere is Thesal's, and Thesal's account is four people over eight hundred years: hospice sisters writing at four bedsides in four different centuries, none of whom had read the others, all four describing somebody going through a thing at a scale that does not fit inside a person and then getting up in the morning and eating breakfast.

Two of those four came apart and two did not. That is the whole of the comparison available to anybody in the world, and Thesal has drawn conclusions from it anyway, because four is what there is. One of the four kept a garden and an argumentative disposition for sixty years. One was gone inside a decade — not dead, but by the end difficult to

distinguish from anybody else the world has decided is mad. The sisters went looking in both histories for what made the difference and could not find it in either.

None of the four is on record as having said what was in the dreams. The hospices never wrote a word of it down, because there was never anything on the page.

Reading one

Divination works on an exemplar the way it works on anybody, right up until it reaches the thing they cannot say. Then the spell ends. **A magical effect that attempts to read these specific thoughts or memories fails automatically** — no save, no counteract check, nothing to resist. The caster is left knowing their own working quit on them and not knowing why.

This has been written down twice. A Dalstan inquisitor three hundred years ago filed it as a demonic ward and acted on the filing. A Melisor magister a hundred and forty years later recorded what happened accurately, had nobody to attempt it on a second time, and sealed the paper. Neither knew of the other. That is the literature.

An exemplar finds it out for themselves, usually by having it done to them, and works out from there that the door swings both ways. There is a knack to hauling the worst of it up to the front of your head and holding it there while somebody reaches in. Nobody teaches it. There has never been anybody to teach it.

Show Them the Red  (divine, exemplar, mental)

Trigger You attempt a saving throw against a mental effect.

Effect You bring the visions forward and let whatever is reaching for you arrive in the middle of them. You gain a +2 circumstance bonus to that save.

Any exemplar can do this once their spark has been focused. It is not a feat, it does not need selecting, and it costs nothing but the reaction. It is also plainly visible to anyone watching, and you do not get to pick which part of it comes up.

How the world takes it

Nobody has a satisfactory doctrine and everybody has a position, which is what happens when a court has to rule on a thing it will see once.

Nation	Position
Thesal Theocracy	Takes them in, asks nothing, charges nothing, and has quietly noted that Sarenrae declines to comment. Four have died of old age in Concord's hospices across eight hundred years, which is more firsthand knowledge of exemplars than the rest of the world holds put together
Dalstan	Holds two rulings at once. The Cathedral Court has declared exemplars living proof of grace, and has separately declared unowned divinity a heresy. It has had two cases in four hundred years. The wealthy one was grace
Lazarian Lichdom	A resource, catalogued as one. The Lichdom has never held one. It has tried three times that anyone can document, and the oldest attempt is in a chronicle rather than a file
Melisor Magocracy	Three academies once bid for the same exemplar, and one of the three bids was not, on review, entirely voluntary. The Council of Archmages sealed its ruling and has never had occasion to write another

Nation	Position
Thurigypst	Pharasma's priest-kings find them acutely difficult — an exemplar's soul carries something that is not the person's and not any god's, and no rite in the faith says where that part goes. They are kind to exemplars and they do not like to be near one
Quivar	Has a file. It is thin, it is three centuries old, and it has never been closed
Nordheim	Would follow one. Has, twice in all the sagas, and both end badly in the same way
Khazan Khaganate	A sign, read as favourable, which is why the Khagan's court has twice been embarrassed by an exemplar who did not want the job. The two occasions are six hundred years apart and the second court had forgotten the first
Sahenna Compact	The Storytellers hold six names, recorded precisely and interpreted not at all. Four of the six are Thesal's. That register is the closest thing the world has to a complete one

Playing one

An exemplar PC is a singular thing in this setting, and the word is meant literally: there is probably nobody else awake in the world. Not one of a tradition, not one of an order, and not one of a dozen at the table's own level. Some consequences worth agreeing on in session zero:

- **No church can vouch for you and no church can excommunicate you**, which cuts in both directions in a world with a Cathedral Court in it.
- **Divination gets a straight answer about everything except you**. Where the spark came from returns nothing — not a refusal, not a lie, not a warning. Silence, from every god asked.
- **Your ikons will be recognised** by anyone with real theological training, and the recognition is *what is that* rather than *whose is that*.
- **You are worth more than a title to at least four nations**, and only one of them would ask first. None of the four has had the chance in living memory, which is not the reassurance it sounds like — it means nobody's policy has ever been tested and everybody's is theoretical.
- **Something in you points south** and will not explain itself. You can ignore it for years. You will not be able to argue with it. See The Wildlands.
- **You will know something you cannot tell the rest of the party**. Not a secret you are choosing to keep. The words do not arrive and the ink does not stay, and neither is under your control. Settle with the GM early how that gets handled at the table. Handled well it is what the class is for here; handled badly it shuts the other players out of a scene, and the whole difference is in the playing: a character visibly failing to get something out is compelling for an evening, and a character who knows and smirks is tiresome inside ten minutes.

Divine artifacts

The same trace turns up in objects as well as in people — relics that are genuinely divine and belong to no faith, no saint and no recorded miracle. They are rare, they are old, they are exceptionally valuable, and no church in Saeroth has ever produced a convincing account of where they come from.

The relic trade knows this and does not advertise it. A certificate from Dalstan's Cathedral Court establishes provenance to a saint. It establishes nothing about the object.

You cannot repeat any of this. Not to the party, not on paper, not in stone.

The dreams

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Once your spark is focused the dreams start, and there is no record of an exemplar to whom they did not. You do not choose which one arrives. On a night one comes, roll, and then save against it: a good dream is something you are trying to hold on to, and a bad one is something you are trying to get clear of.

Nothing in any of them can be repeated. You already know that part.

The save

On waking, the exemplar attempts a **Will save** against the level-based DC for their level: 15 at 1st, 20 at 5th, 27 at 10th, 34 at 15th, 43 at 20th.

The save does different work on each half of the table. On a **good** dream you are holding on to something. On a **bad** one you are getting clear of it.

Degree	Good dream (11–20)	Bad dream (1–10)
Critical success	The effect, and your first Will save today is rolled twice, higher result	No effect, and your first Will save today is rolled twice, higher result
Success	The effect	No effect
Failure	No effect. You remember splendour and cannot get back to it	The effect
Critical failure	No effect, and your first Will save today is rolled twice, lower result	The effect, and your first Will save today is rolled twice, lower result

Every effect lasts until the exemplar's next daily preparations unless it says otherwise.

The table

1d20	The dream	What it leaves
1-2	Forgotten	–2 status penalty to Diplomacy, Performance and Society. Strangers who meet you today will not remember having done so
3-4	The nothing	–1 status penalty to Perception. You are slowed 1 for the first round of your first encounter today
5-6	Twelve ways	–1 status penalty to AC
7-8	The bleeding	The first time today you take piercing or slashing damage, you also take 1d4 persistent bleed damage
9-10	The murdered	The first time in each encounter an ally is reduced to 0 Hit Points, you become frightened 2
11-12	The office	Once today, attempt one skill check as though trained in that skill, or expert if already trained
13-14	Worship	Once today, gain a +2 status bonus to a Diplomacy, Intimidation or Performance check

1d20	The dream	What it leaves
15-16	The judgement	Once today, one Strike against a fiend, an undead, or a creature that has knowingly profaned a holy place deals an extra 2d6 spirit damage
17-18	The strength	Once today, gain a +2 status bonus to one attack roll, damage roll or Athletics check
19-20	Elysium	Once today, roll a saving throw twice and use the higher result (fortune)

1-2 Forgotten

A name is not a label when you are the thing being named. It is the whole of your body. Eleven million mouths are carrying you and you can feel every one of them, the way a person feels their own hands without looking. Then a temple in a border province is rededicated to a neighbour of yours, and it is like a finger going numb. It happens again the following spring, four provinces over, and there is no thread between the two that you can find. A scribe copies out a liturgy and drops one syllable, and you lose the ability to be spoken of in the past tense, and nobody notices because nobody has needed to speak of you in the past tense yet. Somewhere in the second generation of it you try to say your own name and discover that you are not one of the mouths that count.

By the end there are three provinces of very old men who still have you. They say you badly. You love them for it in a way that would be embarrassing if there were anybody left to be embarrassed in front of. Then there is a public health measure.

You are still there afterwards. That is the part that does not stop. Nothing kills you, you are simply no longer held up by anything, and you can feel yourself going thin, and you have several months to watch it happen.

3-4 The nothing

There is nothing in this one, which is why the exemplars who get it come out worse than the ones who get the knives.

No floor. No direction, no light and no dark, and nothing arriving from anywhere. You are entirely intact, and that is the trouble: every faculty you ever had for attending to a world is open and working and has nothing whatsoever to attend to, so it turns around and begins attending to itself, and finds that it has already been doing that for some time. You count. You lose count, start again, and cannot establish whether the second count is the first one. You compose an argument about your own situation, follow it to the end, and find at the end of it the same argument, which you now suspect you have composed before.

At some point you understand that this is not a punishment and not a place. It is what is left over when there is nothing to be the god of. It has no edges and no duration and no door.

The exemplar wakes with it still in their mouth, and spends the morning touching the walls of the room to confirm that the room has walls. That habit does not always go away.

5-6 Twelve ways

Twelve hooks go in and no two of them pull the same direction.

They are hooks. Iron, or whatever iron is when it has been made for this, and they go in under the ribs, through both shoulders, into the joints of the hands, into the hinge of the jaw. Then they pull, steadily and without any particular hurry, because a body your size does not come apart quickly and everybody involved knows it. Skin goes first. It goes the way wet canvas goes, in a seam that opens a foot and stops and opens another foot, and you can hear it happening from inside. Then the muscle, which does not tear so much as fray, one cord after another, each of them a separate event with its own arrival. Then the joints. A hip the size of a hill leaves its socket over the better part of an afternoon and there is a sound at the end of that which you will still be hearing in the last of the twelve places you end up.

You do not die of any of it. That is what the three generations of paperwork were for. You are awake for the first arm. You are awake for the second arm. You are awake when they open the chest along the breastbone and it gives like a barred door being forced, and awake for what is behind it, and awake while they take that out as well and it goes on working in the hands of a man standing on your sternum to get the leverage.

Near the end your own weight starts doing the work for them. What is left is hanging off itself, tearing under its own load in twelve directions at once, and every one of those tears is slow enough to be attended to individually. You cannot fall. There is nothing left to fall with.

The exemplar wakes up intact. They lie still for a while in the dark, going over themselves with both hands, checking.

7-8 The bleeding

The knives are small. Nobody expects that. A thing like you cannot be killed by anything the size of a sword, so they use something the size of a sword eleven thousand times, and eleven thousand more, and the wounds close behind them at precisely the rate they are opened. It never becomes an injury and it never stops being a wound. You have time to get bored, and then time to be frightened by how bored you are, and then time to work out that being bored is also part of the method.

All the while you are draining, and you can feel where it goes. Down, in a long fall, onto a green world with rivers in it and people living on the rivers who have done nothing to anybody and are, by the second day, looking up.

It runs for seven days and you watch every hour of it land. You watch a woman on a riverbank put her hands over her son's head to keep you off him. There is nothing you can do about that, and there is no version of you left that could have done anything about it, because you are the weather now.

9-10 The murdered

Three provinces of old priests, the last few hundred anywhere who can still say it correctly, and you are inside every one of them while it is done, because being inside them is what being their god consists of.

It is not done cruelly. It is done as a sanitation order, signed in one city and countersigned in another, carried out over eleven days by men working to a schedule who break for the midday meal and complain about the walking. One of them is decent about it and apologises first. You are in the priest being apologised to. You are also in the man apologising, because he was baptised in your name forty years ago and nobody ever told him whose name it was.

You go out of the world three hundred and some times. Each one is a small door closing and you are on the far side of every one of them, still there, with fewer doors.

The last is a woman of eighty who gets your name wrong at the end because she is frightened and her mouth is not working properly. That is the version that survives. That is the last time you are ever said.

11-12 The office

You are doing the thing you are for, and it is going well.

You will not be able to say afterwards what it is. It takes both hands and the whole of your attention and some faculty a person does not have and has never missed. It is enormous. It is also completely routine, and you have done it every day since before there was anybody in the world to notice you doing it, and there is a deep and unshowy satisfaction in doing it properly.

That satisfaction is the injury. The exemplar wakes in a rented bed with their hands still moving through a motion that has no name, and they will make that motion again for the rest of their life without meaning to, at a table, in a fight,

halfway through a sentence, and never be able to explain to anybody why stopping partway feels like putting down something they were carrying for somebody else.

Nothing in SaerOTH needs doing that way any more. Nobody has done it in two and a half thousand years. Nobody has noticed that it has gone undone.

13-14 Worship

A city says your name at the same time, and it is not the begging kind.

It is the ordinary kind. Over bread, at a door before a journey, under the breath of a man doing sums he does not trust, by a girl who is furious with her sister and wants you specifically to know about it. It comes in all day from every direction like weather, and not one word of it asks you to be impressive. They assume you are there the way they assume the floor is there. You are held up so completely and so continuously that standing on your own has never once been a thing you have had to think about, or could think about, or would know how to begin.

Then the exemplar wakes up in a room where nobody is saying anything. They have to get out of a bed, in a body, and carry it around all day among people who like them well enough.

Two of the four exemplars Thesal has firsthand records of began going wrong after this dream rather than after any of the ones with knives in them.

15-16 The judgement

Something has got in that should not have got in, and you take it apart.

The taking apart is not a fight. It has the unhurried competence of a man rehangng a gate that has been dragging all summer: you find the place where it is wrong, you open it there, and you go on opening until there is no more of it to open. It screams the whole time, in a register that would stop the heart of anything mortal standing nearby, and you note that the way you would note rain on the way to somewhere. Mercy does not present itself as an option you are declining. It does not present itself at all. You are not being cruel. You are being correct, and from where you are standing the difference is as plain as the difference between wet and dry.

The exemplar wakes with that certainty still in them, entire, for about four seconds.

A few of them spend the rest of their lives trying to get back to it, and those are not the ones you want anywhere near a courtroom.

17-18 The strength

You could put your hand through the sky.

Not as a boast. You know the thickness of it the way you know the width of your own shoulders, you know exactly how it would go and what the sound would be, and you know what would come through afterwards and roughly how long it would take to deal with. You do not do it. There is no reason to. The not-doing takes no effort at all and leaves no mark on the day.

Then the exemplar wakes into a body that gets short of breath going up a hill, that can be held down by two men with a rope, that will one day be finished off by something as small as bad water in a town they were only passing through. They spend the whole of that day very slightly wrong about doors, about what things weigh, about how far away the ceiling is.

One of Thesal's four came out of it and walked off a harbour wall in the dark, in the flat certainty that the drop was nothing, and kept the limp for thirty years.

19-20 Elysium

All of them are there.

The light is going through everything, including you, and you are one of the things it is worth going through.

Somebody you have known since before the world had a name says something to you from across the room and it is not important and everybody laughs, and you laugh, and you belong there so completely that belonging is not a thing it would occur to you to notice, any more than you notice being the right temperature.

That is the entire dream. Nothing in it is frightening. There is no blood anywhere in it.

The exemplar wakes in a rented bed, in a body that has to be fed and emptied and kept warm, among four or five people who like them well enough and will be dead within fifty years. They now know the size of the thing they are not going to get.

It is the roll every exemplar hopes for. In two of Thesal's four case files it is the entry the sisters later marked as where the bad years started.

You cannot repeat any of this. Not to the party, not on paper, not in stone.